



"The whole idea with FLOSS software is that it doesn't matter who owns it even remotely as much as it does for closed-source software. So they [customers and users] can continue to use MySQL whatever happens. And there are still tons of good MySQL support people at Sun, so there is no problem buying support from Sun."

—David Axmark, co-founder, MySQL Database

enterprise software market, and just like Microsoft, once it gets one product to a customer, it will try and use that installation as a lever to get other products in. Up till now, those at Oracle haven't made a serious attack on the desktop space. Maybe OpenOffice.org will give them an incentive to do so," says McCreesh.

He also warns that if something goes wrong at Oracle, the OOo community as a whole will not hesitate in making the office suite an independent entity. He points out, "There have been discussions around creating a foundation for the independent development of OOo. I think that's a real possibility if Oracle is not interested in OpenOffice.org or withdraws the sponsorship that Sun Microsystems used to provide."

Well, to twist around an old fashioned greeting a little, "May the fork be with you!"

Hitting at Microsoft

Customers are looking for heterogeneous environments, and they find Red Hat and Oracle to be a

better choice than Microsoft. While Red Hat is the leading open source company, Oracle offers a mix. The latter will be able to address any query that a customer might have regarding the entire stack—from the operating system layer to the application layer.

The buyout of Sun will put Oracle in a much stronger position against its 'favourite' rival Microsoft. Let's face it—Ellison never misses an opportunity to punch Microsoft. This is the first time he will have all the required arrows in his quiver to make a dent in Microsoft's armour.

The company is now a complete vendor—it has its own hardware, operating systems to run on those hardware, middleware, the mother Java, the most popular databases (whether open source or proprietary), an office suite, and many more technologies. Seems like it's becoming a multi-polar world, with Microsoft, IBM and Oracle in the ring.

And let's face it, most customers would prefer going for Oracle's stack than Microsoft's. The fact is that many

companies are migrating to GNU/Linux and Microsoft has been doing nothing but token lip service regarding its uncertain and dubious interoperability efforts. In the case of Oracle, everything will be well-optimised and well supported. If customers face any problems—from operating system to database, or office suite to middleware, all they have to do is dial Oracle.

This seems to be an end to the dominant, dictatorial Microsoft era. IBM, on the other hand, will also have a giant to compete with. The three players will keep a check on each other. The result? The community and the customer will win. 

List of Oracle's open source projects:

- <http://oss.oracle.com/projects/>
- <http://www.oracle.com/technologies/linux/linux-tech-leadership-contributions.html>
- Some other major projects include:
- Oracle modifications to Glassfish Project (CDDL-licensed) source files.
- The Mozilla Thunderbird Extension for Oracle Collaboration Suite users

Unanswered questions

Since both the involved parties are keeping mum, there are several areas where some questions are still unanswered. Tony Wasseman says, "The biggest problem surrounds the GlassFish application server, since Oracle recently acquired BEA with its commercial Java application server. Oracle also had its own Java application server, but I don't think that they are still investing in its development. I would not be surprised if Oracle reduced the staffing commitment to GlassFish, but that is not the same as killing the project."

By: Swapnil Bhartiya

A Free Software fund-a-mental-ist and Charles Bukowski fan, Swapnil also writes fiction and tries to find cracks in a proprietary company's 'paper armours'. He is a big movie buff and prefers listening to music at such loud volumes that he's gone partially deaf when it comes to identifying anything positive about proprietary companies. Oh, and he is also the assistant editor of *EPYTimes.com*.